



**RETAIL HEAVEN:** A typical day at Mumbai's Hypercity mall

BHASKAR PAUL

**143 m**

is the total area, in square feet, to be developed for shopping malls across the country by 2010

**60,000**

are the footfalls that a big mall gets over weekend. The number comes down to 18,000 on weekdays.

ing their leisure time. Plays, movies and family outings have now been replaced by a day-long visit to the mall. "We are witnessing a revolution in India. Almost 90 cities and towns will have malls over the next few years," says Kishore Biyani, CEO of the Future Group. In 2001, India had only three shopping malls, but by 2010, the figure could reach 525.

The secret of the success lies in a mix of offerings for everyone—high-end brands, discount stores, gaming for kids, fast food, fine dining options and a multiplex. Better infrastructure and increased spending power in Tier 2 and 3 cities are attracting developers like Omaxe, Parsvanth, Vatika and Ansals. These malls are also fuelling aspirational consumption, which is the reason why the Fortune Group ensures its Big Bazaar in any small town has a more up-market feel than the store in Mumbai.

The first brush with modernism over, retail space is getting more segmented. Concept and niche malls are gradually making their presence felt—from the Gold Souk in Gurgaon, the Attitude Furniture Mall in Bangalore to a healthcare mall in Kolkata. Eleven specialised malls will be operational over the next two years, with industry estimates showing that the conversion rate at a specialty mall goes up to 70 per cent compared to 30 per cent at regular malls. "But in India, only gold and wedding goods are strong destination concepts," says B.S. Nagesh, MD of Shoppers Stop Ltd.

The growing demand for shopping destinations will see a plethora of malls coming up in the next few years in India. But the high concentration of malls in a few areas

is also causing clutter, currently being seen in Gurgaon, Haryana, which will have over 20 new malls by the end of 2007. "Currently, anyone who has a plot builds a mall. But most don't have good infrastructure and strong retail tenants. There are so many malls with just partial occupancy," says Nagesh. But Gibson Vedamani, CEO of the Indian Retailers' Association, sees it differently. "It's a positive trend that so many malls are coming up today. Competition leads to better facilities so each one will keep innovating, which is in turn good for the consumer." The genie has escaped the magic lamp. ■

**AJAY PIRAMAL**, promoter of Crossroads, 2000

**"We have tried to get something for everybody under a single roof."**

■ **By Aditi Pai**

**G**ujarati thali for lunch, fabulous deals at the hypermarket, the finest fashion labels and the latest movie at the multiplex. It's a Sunday ritual for Darshan Kothari's family at Inorbit Mall, the 150-million-sq feet hotspot in suburban Mumbai that attracts about a million footfalls a month. "It's a one-stop destination for all our shopping and entertainment needs," says the 32-year-old businessman.

For an affluent India, the call of the mall is proving to be irresistible. And the "shoppertainment experience" is changing the way Indians are spend-